How to write text descriptions (alt text) in BBC News articles

This guidance is for staff who use digital images when creating content for BBC News.



About text descriptions

An introduction on text descriptions, their benefits, and principles.

v1 30 May 2024



Decorative images

How to write text descriptions for images that are only included for aesthetic reasons.

v1 30 May 2024



Informative images

How to write text descriptions for images that communicate information, convey a mood, or add to the user experience.

v1 30 May 2024



Functional images

How to write text descriptions for images of interactive elements, like links or buttons.

v1 30 May 2024



Images of text

How to write text descriptions when text is burned into the image and can't be read by screen readers or braille displays.

v1 30 May 2024



Complex images

How to write text descriptions for graphs, charts, maps or infographics that convey detailed factual information.

v1 30 May 2024



Describing people

How to write text descriptions for images that include people.

v1 30 May 2024



Captions vs text descriptions

How to differentiate the two descriptions of an image.

v1 30 May 2024



A final checklist

A summary of points to keep in mind.

v1 30 May 2024

Explore the BBC

Home
News
Sport
Business
Technology
Health
Culture
Arts
Travel
Earth
Audio
Video
Live

Terms of Use
About the BBC
Privacy Policy
Cookies
Accessibility Help
Parental Guidance
Contact the BBC
BBC emails for you
Advertise with us

Copyright © 2026 BBC. The BBC is not responsible for the content of external sites. **Read about our approach to external linking.**